



Finches and House Sparrows

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Species Profile

Finches are small to medium-size songbirds with sturdy bills that let them crack open the tough hulls of seeds, their main food. Five species have been known to nest in Pennsylvania. One, the house finch, (*Haemorhous mexicanus*) is a western species liberated in the Northeast that has become quite common. Another, the red crossbill (*Loxia curvirostra*) is a rare nester here, mostly in conifer forests. Finches are sociable birds, and outside of the breeding season they gather in flocks. They feed mainly in trees but will forage on the ground, in tall weeds and in shrubs. Even during summer, when insect populations burgeon, many finches continue to eat seeds and even nourish their young with a pulp composed of regurgitated seeds. They will also eat insects, buds, and fruit. In winter, many of the birds in this group frequent bird feeders but also can be found in conifers and on deciduous trees with catkins such as birches, ashes, maples, and aspens.

Male finches sing to attract females and to maintain pair bonds. Finches tend to be sexually dimorphic with the male's plumage more colorful than the females. In most species, the female builds a cup-shape nest hidden in the thick foliage of a tree or shrub. Female finches do most or all of the incubating, and males and females team up to feed the young.



HAEMORHOUS PURPUREUS

Purple finch

Do not look for a purple bird when trying to pick out this species. The male purple finch is maroon-red, sometimes described as raspberry-colored, while the female is brown with darker streaks. The species breeds across the southern half of Canada and south into the Pacific Northwest, the Great Lakes states and the Appalachian Mountains in the Northeast where it is found as far south as West Virginia and Virginia.

Purple finches



HAEMORHOUS MEXICANUS

House finch

House finches in the eastern United States are descendants of birds released in New York City in 1940. The species is native to the U. S. Southwest; today *Haemorhous mexicanus* breeds from southern Canada, across most of the United States and south through most of Mexico.

House finches

Females are sparrow-like, and males are similar to male purple finches, except that house finches show more streaking on the breast and flanks, are not quite as robust, and are a more bright or "strawberry" red. The red pigment in both species comes from beta-carotene found in many plants, particularly in red fruits; the red blush to the plumage varies with the pigments in the food that is consumed during molt. House finches inhabit urban, rural and suburban environments and have adapted to a wide range of human-associated habitats. In the east, they are often found near human dwellings where they readily visit feeding stations. They feed on seeds, flowers, buds, berries, small fruits and insects.

Pairs often form within flocks during winter. Males do not stake out territories but, instead, defend areas around their mates. House finches begin nesting as early as March and produce two or more broods per year, each with four or five young. Females nest in a variety of sites including conifers, ivy along walls, abandoned nests of other birds, above porch lamps and in hanging flower baskets. The population of this western species "exploded" until around the mid-1990s, when a highly contagious eye disease, Mycoplasma conjunctivitis, caused a dramatic population decline in the East. The disease causes respiratory problems and swollen eyes in house finches. Infected finches often die as a result of starvation, predation or exposure. Some birds do not die and may transmit the disease to flocks in other areas. It is important to regularly clean feeding stations with soapy water to prevent the spread of this disease. Although numbers have declined from peak populations in the mid-1990s, the Second Atlas of Breeding Birds in Pennsylvania shows the house finch to be numerous in Pennsylvania.



Pine siskin

With their brown colors and streaked breasts, pine siskins look like sparrows; patches of yellow in the wings and tails are good field identifiers. Pine siskins nest in Alaska, across Canada, in northern parts of the United States including the upper Great Lakes and New England. They nest in western mountains south into Central America.

Pine siskin



SPINUS TRISTIS

American goldfinch

The male goldfinch in summer is one of Pennsylvania's most conspicuous birds: bright yellow, with black wings and a black forehead. The female is a dull olive-gray. In winter, both sexes look like the summer female. Goldfinches are gregarious and are often seen flying in groups. They have a characteristic bouncing or undulating flight pattern: bursts of wingbeats followed by short glides when the birds lose a few feet of height. While airborne, flock members sound a perchickory call.

American goldfinch



PASSER DOMESTICUS

House sparrow

Although named a "sparrow," this ubiquitous bird is not related to North American sparrows but is related to Old World sparrows. The house sparrow is native to Europe and Asia, and can now be found living with humankind around the globe. This invasive species was introduced into North America between 1850 and 1886 in an attempt to control insect pests, particularly the elm spanworm caterpillar. At first, the bird was called the "English sparrow," because most imports were brought from England. Male house sparrows have black chin and breast patches (the amount of black varies among individuals), white cheeks and a chestnut nape. Females are a dingy brown.

House sparrows

Winter finches

In addition to Pennsylvania's breeding species, four other finches—white-winged crossbill (*Loxia leucoptera*), common redpoll (*Acanthis flammea*), evening grosbeak (*Coccothraustes vespertinus*), and pine grosbeak (*Pinicola enucleator*)—breed in the far north and visit the Northeast in winter, when they may descend on feeding stations in yards. In some years, "winter finches" invade our area; in other years, they stay in the north. Ornithologists believe that finches come south when key food sources, particularly the seeds of conifers, fail in their boreal habitat. Red crossbills (*Loxia curvirostra*) and white-winged crossbills (*Loxia leucoptera*) have oddly shaped bills, the tips of whose mandibles cross. A bird will stick its bill between the scales of a spruce cone, then open the mandibles, prying apart the scales; the bird lifts out the exposed seed with its tongue. The male red crossbill is brick red in color, and the female is a mix of olive-gray and yellow. The white-winged crossbill has white wingbars in both sexes; the male is a rosy pink, and the female is colored much like the red crossbill female. Both types of crossbills eat the seeds of various conifers, and they also feed on buds and weed seeds. In the years when they winter in Pennsylvania, they may arrive with cold fronts in late October and November.



Evening grosbeak

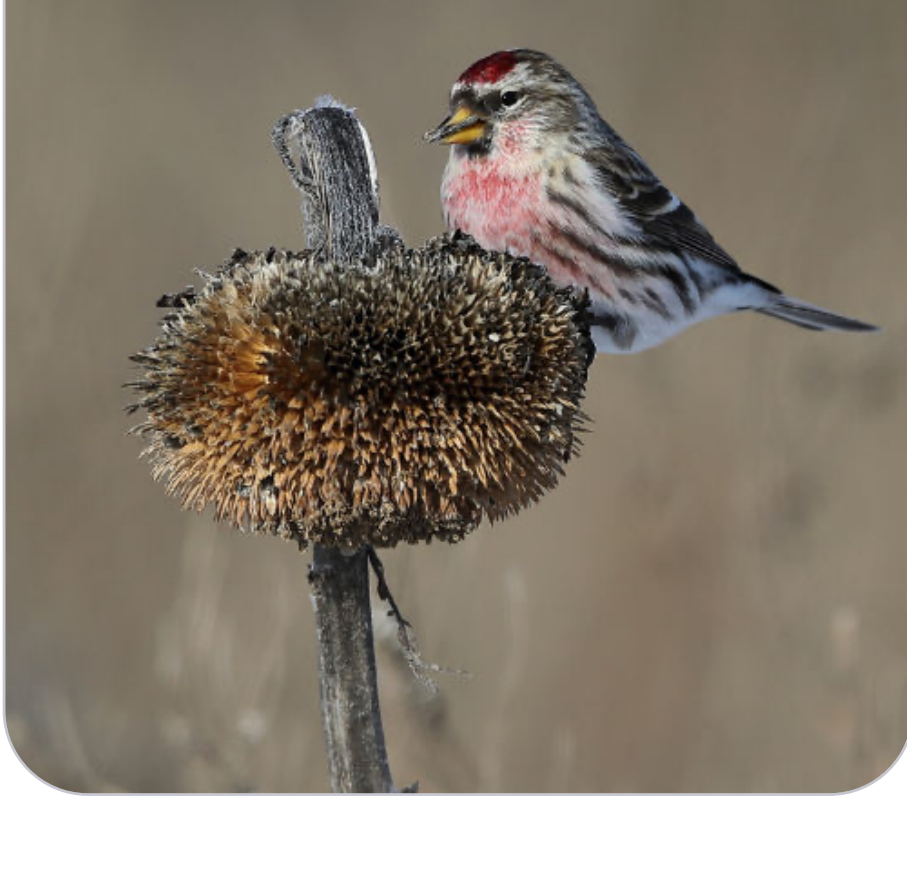
The evening grosbeak is a big, husky bird. The male is dull yellow gray with prominent white wing patches, and the female is yellowish gray; the massive bill is white in both sexes. Wintering flocks wander widely in search of food, although a feeding station frequently restocked with sunflower seeds will hold them in one area. Evening grosbeaks forage in mixed woodlands, coniferous forests, towns and suburbs. At bird feeders, they often displace one another, as well as the local birds, giving strident chirping calls and putting on aggressive displays while competing for food.



PINICOLA ENUCLEATOR

Pine grosbeak

The pine grosbeak is the largest of Pennsylvania's winter finches. It is a grayish bird with a plump chest and round head. The males are reddish-pink on their head, chest and back, while females and immature birds vary from orange to yellow. Their diet is almost exclusively plant-based (buds, seeds and fruits) generally from spruce, pine, juniper, birch, maple, poplars, and more. During winter, pine grosbeaks can be seen eating grit and salt along roadsides and visiting feeders with black oil sunflower seeds or suet.



CARDUELIS FLAMMEA

Common redpoll

The common redpoll has a red forehead and a black chin. It is the size of a goldfinch. Redpolls feed actively in brushy and weedy fields and along woods edges, picking up seeds of trees, weeds and grasses. Often they forage in mixed flocks with pine siskins and goldfinches.

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